

human and we are not talking enough on our condition. At the end of that data or technology or whatever stimulus we are putting into the world, we are all motivated by very similar things like love, friendship, care, laughter or connectivity. Those things are what drive the human condition. That will not change.

Q: Do you want to hazard a guess on what advertising will look like in the next 5-10 years?

DB: I think there will be more nonsense and crappy content. But the people who will win are those who understand humans well.

PP: In fact, when we keep speaking to each other, we agree that idea is God.

DB: IBM did a study across 1,500 CEOs. The question put forth was, 'What are the most important values for your company?' Integrity was at No. 2 and can you guess what topped the list? It was creativity. When I talk directly to CMOs, things happen a lot faster. As things go down the organisation, it's about someone's job being data or influencer marketing and I get that since it is about livelihood. But the idea is nobody's job. Actually, jobs have become siloed channels and we have created an industry that is thinking that way.

Q: There is a spree of inorganic activity across the world with digital agencies being acquired. How do you view this?

DB: If you don't look at it through the lens of an agency and just a business, my belief is that at the core, identifying the adjacencies is important. It must be a healthy, vital business and one that offers scaleable, sustainable growth. What's happened in the agency world is about, 'Oh my God, here is digital transformation and I am going to make this acquisition!' We are constantly trying to make ourselves something else and that is where the role of holding companies becomes important.

But at a brand level or the agencies, we must think about our core and how we evolve our offering in the marketplace. Let me give you an example here. One of the questions I ask all the time in relation to acquisitions (and we have a lot of assets across the world) is who's our buyer? If our buyer is not the marketing organisation, then the question is should we be going to a different buyer? I don't have an answer to that but it is a strategic question. Then, I need to understand what my organisation is since all I have is talent. It's the same thing our clients do. They want to know who's buying their products and what am I creating since all I have is people. When I am told how our client leaders need to sell digital transformation, my reaction is 'How?' They have grown up doing something else. Sometimes, we forget to have strategic discussions about our own business and we

"People ask me for a five-year plan... My personality is really about figuring out 'how to get it done'. That means you have a plan but that has to be achievable. If you create these pies in the sky, you cannot get things done"

DEVIKA BULCHANDANI
GLOBAL CEO, OGILVY

get enamoured by new things because the narrative is doom and gloom. For instance, it could be panic about 'Deloitte is coming or Facebook is here or what do I do with AI?' Then, you stop to think strategically.

PP: We are still here and evolving. Two months ago, I went to deliver a lecture at Deloitte. I think times are changing. It was about creativity and the value of ideas. The first thing I told them was you guys are used to Deloitte and I am going to talk to you about delight!

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Q: What does it mean to be a woman CEO in the modern world? Do you wake up to that thought each morning?

DB: I wake up in the morning wondering what problem I have to tackle! There is an indication of a shift but it's not easy to answer that question. There are days when I think it's tougher to be a woman leader and that's not because of what the world expects of me. Rather, it's about what I expect of myself. Perhaps, a male boss would have done something differently and there are days when I want to make myself inaccessible and five minutes later, it's about 'Who am I kidding?' Honestly, it's no straight journey and I don't wake up to one thought. It must be a constant work in progress. The secret is just to get on with it and keep moving. It's very important for me to show other women that it can be done and I am quite militant about it. They must get a seat at the table but I don't stand up at forums to say that. Someone once told me about how I never speak about being a brown woman. My response was, 'I never speak about being a woman.' To me, you just act it by giving someone a seat at the table. My view is talk is easy but action is hard. My goal in life is to get an award that is not for women. Nothing would make me happier than being acknowledged as a professional leader. **BT**

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